

Canon EOS 400D

In A League Of Its Own

After setting the market on fire and creating a new category of affordable D-SLRs, Canon ups the ante by launching the successor to the hugely popular 350D. The new EOS 400D—also known as the 400D Rebel XT in other parts of the world—is a 10 MP compact digital SLR. For an amateur, the plethora of settings available might overwhelm, but then that's what should be expected of an SLR.

Light and compact it surely is; however, manual controls and performance are pretty much there despite the camera being an entry level D-SLR. New features include a nine-point AF sensor, a dust cleaning system via an anti-static coating on the sensor, and software-based dust



pattern removal. There's a large 2.5-inch LCD, but the status LCD has been shown its way out. An eye proximity sensor makes the LCD switch off while the frame is being composed.

Ergonomically, the Canon 400D is near-perfect: nice large buttons, solid-looking command dials, and a massive grip.

The new nine-point AF offers a significant advantage in terms of

focusing sharply on the subject. "Nine-point" means the viewfinder has nine spots that light up green when the shutter is half depressed, indicating the selected area.

ISO speeds are available from 100 all the way up to 1600—good for taking low-light photographs. Twelve shooting modes and eight white balance settings are available for instant shooting. Monochrome pictures can also be shot, apart from other available presets.

On the performance front, the 400D gives excellent results; colours are typical Canon—natural and soothing. Noise is pretty well restricted till ISO 400, after which you do

get to see significant noise (chroma noise; colour speckles that happen when photos are taken in poorly-lit areas or when the ISO is cranked up). The sharpness, however, remains intact.

White balance isn't the camera's strong point, and in our studio test, a yellow cast was prominent.

The 400D is pricey at Rs 56,995 for the body and the 18-55 kit lens. However, a good starting camera for amateur photographers, we think, would be Nikon's D40. It makes for an excellent buy because of its aggressive pricing.

Specifications

10.1 Megapixel APS-C CMOS sensor, Digic II Imaging processor, Nine-point AF Sensor, 3 FPS continuous shooting, 1/4000 to 1/200 sec maximum shutter speed and ISO 100-1600

Contact: Canon India Pvt Ltd
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Web site: www.canon.co.in
Price: 56,995

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Acer PD527D

Feature-heavy, Light Performer

After Acer's victory in our projector comparison in March, we wanted to test another model in their "PD" series: the PD527D looks diminutive compared to the massive-looking PD726W. Built well, the PD527D has a silver and dark grey tone to it, which may or may not appeal. What did attract was the cosmetic blue/red LED embedded on the power button—very cool.

With S-Video, Component, DVI, and D-Sub connectivity, the PD527D is quite well connected. The cheat is the secondary VGA, which connects to a Component connector which is provided (Component connectivity isn't native). There's a USB type B port too, though we didn't receive a wired controller. The sleek remote looks like a miniature replica of the PD726Ws

unit. The mandatory audio-in (3.5-mm) and RS-232 interface are also present. Wi-Fi connectivity is absent.

With a lower brightness and contrast ratio than its larger sibling, we weren't expecting performance to be in the same league. True to our expectations, the PD527D wasn't up to the mark in the horizontal and vertical resolution tests, where there was noticeable banding. Performance was good in the colour tests—no streaking or ghosting of any sort. However, we noticed some changes in shade intensity in the black level shift test; the white level shift test was, however, aced. Colour purity is good, and the great sharpness makes it good for working with Web pages, presentations and documents.

So it's good for your office, but what about at

home? To be honest, this isn't for the gamer, who'll be looking for a high contrast ratio to begin with. F.E.A.R. didn't look as good as we're used to seeing it—limited greyscale intensity. Thankfully, movies are more forgiving, and the PD527D is a good addition to a home-entertainment system.

For just over a lakh, it's well priced compared to its better-performing sibling (the PD726W), but hard to

recommend simply because NEC's NP40 handles every task better, while occupying less space, and costing a good ten per cent less.

Specifications

Specifications: 3000 ANSI, 2000:1 contrast ratio, 2.9-8.0 Throw distance, digital zoom, keystone correction, 720p and 1080i HDTV compatible, DVI (HDCP) digital input and 2000 Hrs lamp life.

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Price: Rs 1,00,000



RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★